



MONTHLY UPDATE

Eswatini: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-08 • 35 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • FINANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • DIGITALISATION • TECHNOLOGY
• CAPACITY • INCLUSION

Summary of the month

Data-protection rules were drafted and applied in the same month. Sector guidelines were validated at a week-long workshop, with the financial sector topping customer-information leaks, the ICT minister told the Senate the national data governance policy is targeted for completion before the end of the year, and the Data Protection Act reached online naming and shaming, exposing it to a E100,000 penalty. Restrictions on children's access to social media were raised in the Senate, and online media publishing guidelines are stated complete though not published.

On the delivery side, a second community innovation hub opened at Macetjeni in the Lubombo region, with artificial-intelligence, robotics and cybersecurity training announced as the next phase; the agriculture ministry handed 44 digital devices to extension officers; and the Auditor-General launched a 2026-2030 strategic plan putting artificial intelligence at the centre of public-sector accountability – in a country whose own artificial-intelligence strategy this ledger records as not held.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The National Data Governance Policy is still being written. The ICT minister told the Senate it is targeted for completion before the end of 2026, with government undecided between a standalone instrument and a broader one. The text is not published and no adoption date is given; being undecided on the instrument's form is itself a statement about how far the drafting has got.

Legislation and regulation

In the same 4 August answer, the ICT ministry said it had completed the Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026, introducing a registration requirement for online publishers bound to accuracy, privacy protection, child safeguarding and the responsible use of AI. Neither the text nor a commencement date is public.

Data protection

The next day ESCCOM, as the data protection authority, began validating draft advisory guidelines on the lawful processing of personal health data at Ezulwini, with the health ministry, providers, insurers, pharmacies and medical aid schemes. They will be published as a regulatory instrument under the Data Protection Act 2022, covering collection, retention, sharing, breach notification, cloud services and patient rights. The commission disclosed that it has concluded a complaint over a practitioner's unlawful disclosure of a patient's information.

In August the same rule-making reached a second sector and produced a ranking. A week-long workshop [validated draft sector data-protection guidelines and produced a proposed whistle-blower-protection framework, with the regulator naming the financial sector as the leading source of personal-data breaches](#) — through misdirected statements and invoices, and cybersecurity incidents exposing customer records. No breach count, penalty or enforcement action is published behind the ranking, and the draft guidelines are not held.

Regional collaboration

The King was [elected Chairperson of the SADC Organ on Politics, Defence and Security Cooperation](#) at the bloc's 46th summit in Durban on 17 August. It is a security portfolio, not a digital one, and no ICT or data responsibility attaches to it in the communique.

A second regional channel opened alongside the SADC one. The Digital Cooperation Organization's secretary-general [met the ICT minister on cooperation to accelerate digital transformation, the country presenting 1.76m mobile connections against a population of about 1.3m and 95% fourth-generation coverage](#). These are exploratory talks with no memorandum, work programme or membership step recorded, and the connection and coverage figures are the government's own.

Standards

Asked on 4 August how online publications comply with the data-protection law, the ICT ministry [answered that implementation, enforcement and oversight do not fall within its direct mandate](#) but are vested in ESCCOM.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The regulator drew a line in public. ESCCOM [stated that cyberbullying is a criminal offence under the computer crime statute](#). Stating an existing offence is a step short of enforcing it: the record held carries no prosecution, complaint volume or reporting route created alongside the statement.

Finance

New investments

A domestic internet provider put [E570,000 into free wireless access across the nine-day national trade fair](#), its third consecutive year as official sponsor. It is the month's only new private digital commitment on this ledger, and it is a sponsorship rather than an investment.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The one dated position here is a standing statutory right rather than a change. Free adjudication of consumer complaints against communications providers [runs under the Eswatini Communications Commission Act 2013, with windows of one month for post and courier, three for broadcasting and six for telecommunications](#). It is structural provision and not movement: no complaint volume, adjudication count or outcome is published against it.

Cybersecurity

Government applications got somewhere to be tested. Eswatini [opened a Government Mobile App Testing Lab, funded and supported by the government of the Republic of China \(Taiwan\)](#). Testing capacity is the practical end of the cybersecurity legislation still awaiting assent. Nothing in the record held says what the lab has tested, or whether testing is a condition of any application going live.

DPI

Digital Identity and CRVS

The home affairs ministry [asked citizens to check that the chief code on their identity documents matches their actual chieftdom](#), warning that an incorrect code creates difficulty in reaching government services. Six months after card production resumed from a technical suspension, the maintenance question has moved from the machine to the record.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The mobile money platform moved underneath its users. An operator [completed migration of its money platform to a cloud-native vendor platform across four African markets](#), this one among them. No downtime, subscriber count or feature change is stated for the Eswatini market, so the base holds that the rail changed hands technically and nothing about what that cost its users.

Registries

Civil registration completeness reached [61 per cent of births and 62 per cent of deaths in 2025](#), against 8.3 and 26.5 per cent in 2016, announced at the ninth Africa civil registration day. The underlying annual report is not held as a downloadable publication.

The social registry began its [second regional rollout in Lubombo on an E41.7 million data-collection exercise](#), two of four regions in two years.

The electoral commission is reviewing a [proposal to make the chief code compulsory at voter registration, alongside a six-month residency rule](#), after it divided residents at Ezulwini — the same code the home affairs ministry was asking citizens to correct eight days later.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The state's auditor put artificial intelligence at the centre of its own next four years. The Auditor-General [launched a strategic plan for 2026 to 2030 naming artificial intelligence and digital transformation as the route to stronger public-sector accountability, urging more than 80 audit officers to adopt them](#), developed with the INTOSAI Development Initiative and the African organisation of English-speaking supreme audit institutions. The plan text is not held, and no tool, data access, assurance standard or safeguard for audit use of artificial intelligence is stated — in a country whose national artificial-intelligence strategy is recorded as *Not held*.

Digitalisation

Rural digital data capture

Rural data collection got hardware rather than a system. The agriculture ministry [handed 40 tablets and 4 laptops, valued at E313,504, to agricultural extension officers on 10 August](#) under an IFAD and Green Climate Fund-backed project, for real-time crop, livestock and weather reporting by officers working with smallholder farmers across all four regions. No officer total, data platform, reporting standard or custodian for the collected field data is stated, so what the reports feed into is not on the record.

Technology

AI

Eswatini's second instrument to carry AI rules arrived in the month, and like the first it is not an AI instrument: the [Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026](#) bind registered publishers to the responsible use of AI, enforced through the registration requirement they create. There is still no national AI strategy or statute behind either.

On 6 July the prime minister told the [Global Dialogue on AI Governance in Geneva](#) that small and developing nations should not become mere consumers of technologies developed elsewhere, an address the National 4IR Strategy frames.

A regional health body and a private firm signed a memorandum in Eswatini on 4 August to scale AI-enabled health solutions, naming no system, no data-sharing terms and no money.

The audit office took its own artificial-intelligence commitment regional, [hosting a week-long peer programme at which supreme audit institutions across the region weighed the use of artificial intelligence in government audit](#). As with the strategic plan in August, no tool, pilot, audit methodology or procurement is named — what the base holds is the intention and the forum it was stated in.

ICT Industry

A state-facing platform changed hands rather than being built. The [Taiwan-funded platform connecting local businesses to wider markets](#) was handed over to the investment promotion authority at the international trade fair on 3 September, with funding for a third-phase scale-up still being sought. No listing count, transaction volume, cost or phase-three budget is published, so what the state has taken on is a platform whose running costs are unstated.

Innovation ecosystem

[Digital transformation was named a priority of the Eswatini-Taiwan relationship](#) at a leaders' meeting in Taipei, with no instrument, figure or implementing agency named; the meeting's own date is not established.

Three days earlier [about 150 delegates — industry leaders, entrepreneurs, policymakers and development partners — met at Manzini under a United Nations enterprise programme on cutting small-enterprise costs with digital tools](#), with no follow-on commitment, tool or funding line published.

Capacity

Training and skills

At the Macetjeni handover the ICT ministry's principal secretary said [AI, robotics, coding and cybersecurity courses would follow](#) at the innovation hubs.

The hub itself opened on 6 August at Macetjeni in the Lubombo Region, [the second of its kind, backed by the development programme with the communications regulator and the small-enterprise development company and aimed at young people, women and people with disabilities](#). It opens against an internet-usage rate of 58% and youth unemployment of 56%. No intake target, running cost or funding term is published, so what a second hub is expected to change cannot be read from the account.

Inclusion

Access to services

The country's second innovation hub opened at [Macetjeni in the Lubombo region on 7 August, extending digital-skills and small-business support to a rural community](#), built by the small enterprise development company with the communications commission and UNDP under a youth empowerment programme, and following the Piggs Peak hub of 2025. No financing figure was disclosed for the facility, and no user, training or enterprise-support count is published for either.

What firms say they need is not more hubs but a network that stays up. At a Mbabane panel on 7 August, logistics, renewable-energy and creator-economy speakers [argued that unreliable connectivity is now a direct cost to business, outweighing any saving from cheaper data](#), describing real-time fleet tracking, remote solar-system monitoring and social-platform market access as core to operations, and urged investment in rural connectivity to widen economic participation. It is a panel of interested parties, and the base holds no reliability series to test it against.

Digital divides

On 6 August the [Macetjeni Integrated Business, Employment and Innovation Hub was launched in the Lubombo Region](#), the second after Pigg's Peak, established by the Small Enterprises Development Company with ESCCOM and UNDP. A third hub is in preparation for Shiselweni, with no start date, provider or cohort size given.

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